

people wore two pieces of clothes made of cotton. The Sangam literature refers to clothes (*Kalingam*, which were thinner than the skin of a snake. Women adorned their hair plaits with flowers. Both men and women wore a variety of ornaments. They were made of gold, silver, pearls, precious stones, conch shells and beads. The People were fond of using aromatic perfumes.

Arts

There are many references to variety of musical instruments such as drum, flute and yazh. Karikalan was master of seven notes of music (*EzhisaiVallavan*). Singing bards were called *panar and viraliyar.* Dancing was performed by *kanigaiyar*. *Koothu* (folk drama) was the most important cultural practice of the people of Sangam Age. They developed the concept of *Muthamizh* (*Iyal*, *Isai*, *Naatakam*).

Occupation

The major occupations of the people were: agriculture, cattle rearing, fishing and hunting. Other craftsmen like carpenter, blacksmith, goldsmith, and potters were also part of the population. Weaving was the most common part-time occupation of the farmers and a regular full time job for many others.

Festivals and Entertainments

People celebrated several festivals. The harvest festival (Pongal) and the festival of spring, kaarthigai were some of them. Indira vizha was celebrated in the capital. There were many amusements and games. This included dances, festivals, bull fights, cock fights, dice, hunting, wrestling and playing in swings. Children played with toy cart and with the sand houses made by them.

Trade

Trade existed at three levels: local, overland and overseas. The extensive and lucrative foreign trade that Tamizhagam enjoyed during this period stands testimony to the fact that Tamils had been great seafarers. Warehouses for storing the goods were built along the coast. The chief ports had light houses, which were called *KalangaraillanguSudar*. Caravans of merchants carried their merchandise to different places in oxen-driven carts. Barter system was prevalent.

Malabar Black Pepper

When the Mummy of Ramses II of the Egypt was uncovered, archaeologists found black pepper corns stuffed into his nostrils and in his abdomen (as a part of embalming process practised in olden days).

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